

A large red square with a white border, centered on a white background. Inside the square, the text "The Personal Statement" is written in white.

The Personal Statement

- This is a 650 - word essay required by all schools that SHOULD be about YOU. The essay is submitted to all colleges and universities that are affiliated to the Common App.
- When reading your essay, admission officers are looking to answer the following questions;
 1. Who is this person?
 2. Will this person contribute something valuable to our campus?
 3. Can this person write?

Qualities of a good personal statement

- Core values - what values are so important to you that you'd fight for?
E.g family.
 - Vulnerability - your essay should be personal, make it come from the gut.
 - Insight - the so whats
 - Craft - how you phrase your sentences and structure your essay down to each word.
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“Pillars” of the personal statement

- Description
- Vulnerability
- Maturity & growth
- Cultural pride
- Magnitude of the topic
- Character
- Global implications and stakes
- Specificity
- Two timely events
- General feel and memorability
- A hook

How will I be vulnerable?

- Vulnerability is one (of four) qualities of an excellent personal statement (in fact, it's the "personal" part)
- It is a great life-skill to learn, and It's one you can get better at as you practice.
- Showcase vulnerability through the following ways;
 1. Writing about your deepest fears
 2. "Shameful" habits like biting nails
 3. Trauma
 4. Ambitions and why they matter to you
 5. Beliefs that you hold eg eating chocolate makes you sweet

Regardless, let your vulnerability come from within. Avoid being superficial!



“When we hit our lowest point, we are open to the greatest change”

-Aang

- When being vulnerable, tell us when you were at your lowest and how you opened up to the greatest change (this is highly relative). Incorporating what you learned through the process amplifies the “personal” part of the common app essay.

The Essence Object Exercise

Object Correlative

An objective correlative is an object with which you correlate emotions, memories, and complex meanings. It's an object that's more than an object.

Every object in your essence object box is an objective correlative for some important, complex part of you.

The only way to express emotion in the personal statement is through an objective correlative.

(Discuss objects with the scholars)

Coming up with a good
narrative

Brainstorming

Brainstorming is an integral facet to writing a stellar essay.

To be more practical, there are two techniques you can use in order to easily access yourself and come up with unique and vibrant topics for your essay.

1. Essence object representation-In this scenario critically think about the objects around you that represent certain values for you or spring up a memorable event that strongly resonates with you (Refer to your list).
 2. 21 Random detail list exercise-here you basically list down a list of random facts about yourself even those that you think are silly.
 3. Walk down memory lane-Mindlessly write down all the memories you can remember, from early childhood to date. Afterwards, identify about 3-5 of those memories that share a common thread, whatever that may be. It could be a moral value or a place, etc.
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Is the topic elastic?

Now assuming you have been able to find a topic after your brainstorming session. Now it's imperative for you to be able to comfortably layout your story into a 650 word essay.

In the event that the topic isn't broad enough to birth a stellar 650 word essay dont worry, there is still a way to go around this issue and still produce a unique subject matter for your essay.

Now common topics tend to have a lot of depth allowing you to easily reproduce a 650 word essay. However this probes the question, “**Will I stand out ?**” Of course you still can. Turning a common topic into a refreshing read is only possible by using **uncommon connections**.

Structure

1. Narrative structure- This is the common structure used that is preferable where an applicant decides to write about a challenge they overcame. This is because the challenge tends to be the main subject matter of the essay thus the narrative structure best fits the subject matter.

2. Montage structure- uses a common theme, object, or event to tie together a bunch of different aspects of the applicant's life.

The Introduction

A wonderful hook- Think of how you can rope your reader in into your narrative voice caging them to be engrossed and fueling them to read through your essay.

This can be done using:

(a) A rather unconventional object which will be used to allude to a certain aspect of your essay or to be used as a symbol that represents something sentimental to you.

(b) A scenario which portrays your vulnerability

(c) A scenario that depicts you doing something you love and exposes your intellectual vitality.

Growth

Broad timespan- Make sure subject matter of the essay is based on two-timely events. This is a strategy to ensure you depict personal or technical growth in your essay. However, note not to sacrifice depth for breadth in a bid to show growth in your essay.

- Growth in your essay is very vital and can be concrete or intangible. A change in perspective, retrospective insights and even progressive realizations in events are facets that can be considered as growth.
 - The use of personal insights in your essay play a big role in showing your vulnerability and can be used as grounds of building emotional implications.
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Description

Show and tell- Now, I am sure you have read the statement and are thinking it should be show not tell however,yes,you have read it right its show and tell. A good essay applies imagery,evocative and visceral descriptions to engross the reader and conveys a strong sense of time, place and self.

However considering you are conversely trying to expressly state some of the your strengths and values the use of 'telling language' is critical to make sure the reader walks away with a clear understanding of what's important to you. **Avoid being too ambiguous.**

An example of telling...

"I come from a diverse background and believe it is important to give 100% in every project I do. Whether it's in school or at work, I always go above and beyond to ensure a successful outcome. I'm also an organized person."

Showing example...

“If you came into my kitchen, which is filled with curries and spices from my home country of Sri Lanka, you would see that all the little jars are organized in alphabetical order. I’ve been doing this type of organization since I was a child. My big sister used to tease me growing up, because even my dolls were arranged in order from biggest to smallest. But when my family decided to move to the United States when I was 15, my organization skills helped me transition into my new life. I made flash cards to study English every day; I meticulously prepared for each quiz and test according to a pre-set schedule; and I practiced soccer after school just like I did in Sri Lanka, just to make sure I kept up my abilities. Thanks to my organizational skills, I was able to quickly excel and became an honor’s student in just my second semester of high school.”

Specificity

- Irrespective of the topic/subject matter specificity is key in developing your ideas and creating a mental image of what's important to you.
 - This also shows that you have a deep understanding/interest in whatever you are passionate about.
 - Especially while talking about complex/technical things, the use of specific technical jargon plays a big role in portraying a deep understanding of what you are talking about.
 - However, be careful not to overdo the technical jargon as this might affect the flow and understanding of the essay.
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Diversity

- Most if not all schools boast about having a rich and diverse community.
 - The realm of diversity is quite wide and most students lock themselves around race, religion and ethnicity. Nevertheless, diversity extends to sexual orientation,sexual identity,gender,income level,first generational status and cultural background.
 - Diversity been a major factor that admission officer use when forming their prospective classes. You want to integrate this into your essay to set you apart.
 - Think of your diversity as an asset that you are offering to the institution to enrich the educational experience for all students.
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my pillow got me into princeton??



reading my college essays!!

My Personal Statement





Tips

- Start journaling
 - Write more
 - Read more newspaper articles, essays and short stories
 - Include interesting details in what you write.
 - Write the essay first, THEN you'll find a prompt that aligns with it.
 - Write in your own voice. It's okay (and preferable) for you to sound as African as you are.
 - BE VULNERABLE
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QUESTIONS?

THE END